THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE **SPORTSWOMEN**

Against All Odds

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Born with phocomelia—a congenital condition that left her without arms—Sheetal has broken barrier after barrier to become one of India's most powerful sporting icons

Sheetal always knew she was different because she did not have arms, but then her feet and toes let her eat, write and climb trees. It was enough in idyllic Loidhar, a remote village in the Kishtwar district of Jammu and Kashmir, where her parents, Mann Singh and Shakti Devi, work as farmers.

Sheetal hadn't even heard of archery. She had gone to Bengaluru in 2020 for medical treatment when she was taken for an assessment. "They told me I had a strong core and suggested three sports, one of which was archery," she recalls. That day became the beginning of a new journey. She started training at the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board Sports Complex in Katra, Jammu.

A 2023 Arjuna awardee, Sheetal uses a custom release device attached to her shoulder. She loads and nocks the arrow with her toes, draws the bow with her body and feet, aims and releases with precision.

Sheetal rose to World No. 1 when she won two gold medals and a silver at the 2022–23 Asian Para Games in Hangzhou. At the Paris 2024 Paralympics, she claimed bronze in the mixed team event, becoming India's youngest Paralympic Olympic medallist at 17. In 2025, she won an individual gold at the World Archery Para Championships in Gwangju by defeating World No. 1 Öznur Cüre Girdi of Türkiye—becoming the first armless woman to win a world title. In a takedown of a significant barrier, she also became the first Indian para-archer selected for the able-bodied junior national team. Coming up next are the 2026 Asian Para Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, where she will defend her titles. ■

— Ishfaq Tantry

HER ADVICE

"Believe in yourself, work hard and keep pushing yourself. When I started, many said I would fail. Had I listened to them, I wouldn't be where I am today. So never let other people's opinions decide your future"